

On Public Reading Rooms

A reading room is a promise made by a town to every person who walks through its door. The promise is simple: knowledge kept on a shelf belongs to anyone who can reach for it. In the town of Samarpur the first reading room opened in 1921 in two rented rooms above a grain shop. It held four hundred books, three newspapers and a single lamp. The committee that ran it wrote in its first report that the doors must open before the mills began their shifts and close after they ended, so that workers could read on the way to work and on the way home.

The committee kept a register of every borrower. By 1925 the register listed more than eleven hundred names, and nearly half of the borrowers had signed with a thumb impression when they first joined. The committee organised evening classes so that members could learn to read the books they borrowed. The report of 1926 says that a reading room should be judged not by the number of books on its shelves but by the number of people who leave able to read a book they could not read before.